

MMA. Sanjeev Sanyal, Varun says, has always been a big sports fan. "Dad didn't really understand the sport or what the prospects were. And it is an injury-prone sport. I can't imagine a parent being too thrilled with their kid going into it," Varun says.

Varun was eventually added to India's Asian Games team in the 77kg category in men's traditional MMA after a rapid rise through the amateur ranks. He won the National Amateur title and the Indian team selection trials before competing at the Asian Mixed Martial Arts Championship in China at the start of the year.

The Asian Games, however, produced an interesting reversal in the father-son relationship. This time, it was Sanjeev who wanted his son to go. Varun had his doubts.

Part of that uncertainty was physical. A staph infection had disrupted his preparations, leaving him with another question to answer before he could think about winning a medal: was he even going to be fit enough to compete?

But the bigger question was whether he was ready. After only a few years as an amateur, and with ambitions of turning professional, Varun wondered if the Asian Games had arrived at the right time in his career.

Competitive urge

Raised in Singapore, Varun was introduced to MMA during national service. Initially, it was a way to learn self-defence and stay fit, but it also gave him an outlet for his competitive instinct. By the time he graduated from university in England, however, he knew this was what he wanted to do.

His progression was rapid.

He made his amateur debut in July 2022 and the following year won the Indian National Amateur Championships. That earned him a place at the World Amateur Championships, where he beat South African champion Liam Schulze and African champion Pedro Calembela before losing to the eventual World Champion Zé Machado.

"He was obviously better than me, but it was one of those things where I was like, okay, he's not unbreachable. There are things that I can do to fix this," Varun says of that loss.

The Asian Championship in China was another step up in class where Varun reached the semifinal, but was beaten again. The bronze medal, based on the government's own criteria, confirmed his place in the Asian Games. After three or four years as an amateur, Varun wanted to turn professional. The ultimate ambition for any fighter, he says, is to reach the major promotions, with the UFC at the top of the list. The Asian Games threatened to complicate that timetable.

There was also a more fundamental issue.

"I don't want to just go there to participate. I want to go there to win," he says.

He looked at the gap between himself and some of the more experienced fighters in the category and wondered whether he could close it between January and September. He told the federation that if another Indian fighter emerged who had a better chance of winning a medal, that fighter should go instead. "I told the federation that if there is a guy who is more qualified, I don't see why he shouldn't get the chance. I want medals for the country," he says.

It was a position that led to an argument with his father. Varun was wrestling with whether the Asian Games was the right decision for his career and whether he had done enough to deserve the opportunity. "He obviously wanted me to go," Varun says. "And he would love for me, as my father, right? Forget my father, even I wanted to go to the Asian Games!"

Awareness of privilege

The disagreement was not about the prestige of representing India. It was about what Varun believed representation should mean and his awareness of the advantages that come with being Sanjeev Sanyal's son.

"There are doors that are open for me that wouldn't be open for other people," he says. "That's the reality, and that's no secret. I was able to go to the UK and Australia and study and train because my father made it possible."

That awareness is why he is wary of using his father's influence to advance his own career. He recalls that early in his career, organisers were willing to take him into international teams without trials. His father instead told him to return to India and fight for his place.

"He was very clear that if I didn't earn my place, I shouldn't deserve to be part of any team. I agree with this. I have a lot of ideas of how MMA should develop in India, and if I ask my father to help me with favours, then it's very hypocritical of me," he says.

Eventually, Varun managed to do both. He beat Karan Nitin Chauhan by rear-naked choke in the first round at Warriors Dream Series 17 in his first professional MMA fight in Mumbai in June and was also included in the Asian Games team.

He knows that when he steps on the mat, there will be plenty of eyes on him, if only for the name he bears. "I want people to know me for what I do on the mat. I want my reputation to belong entirely to me. Not for who my father is or what my last name is," he says.